Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 John

1 John 1:1

That which was from the beginning: This means Jesus existed before time began and is eternal (John 8:58). When Jesus became a human, the apostles gazed upon and touched him (John 1:14). This statement is important because some early groups, such as Gnostics and Docetists, denied that Christ was truly human (see 1 John 4:2–3). These groups taught heresies (false teachings) about Christ

Jesus, the Son of God, is the personal expression of the invisible God. He is the giver of eternal life (John 1:1–4).

1 John 1:1–4

- This opening section, written in the form of a poem, is similar to the message of the beginning of John's Gospel (John 1:1–18).
- The we language in the introduction refers to John and the other apostles, and perhaps to other Christians who had seen and touched Jesus Christ. The apostles personally saw Jesus and had personal fellowship with God through him. John, representing the apostles, now invites those he is writing to join in that fellowship.

1 John 1:2

- This is the life: Throughout the New Testament, the Greek word zōē (which means "life") is used to describe God's own eternal life (for example, Ephesians 4:18). This life is found in Christ, and he gives it to all who believe in him.
- this is the life that was revealed to us: Jesus, the Christ, was known to his apostles as a human being during his earthly ministry.

1 John 1:3

- What we have seen: The Word of life had, as a human being, revealed God to the apostles.
- this fellowship of ours is with the Father and with His Son: After the Spirit gave the apostles new life (regenerated them), they entered spiritual fellowship with the Father and the Son.
- you also may have fellowship with us: Whoever entered into fellowship with the apostles by associating with them while they were alive, or enters now by remaining in their teaching, has fellowship with the Father and the Son through them.

1 John 1:4

so that our joy may be complete: The joy that the apostles have comes from their fellowship with God the Father and the Son (1:3). Those John is writing to will share this joy when they also enter into this close relationship with God.

1 John 1:5

God is light: This means that God is completely pure, good, and true. When Jesus Christ lived on earth, this light shone through him to everyone he met. His life exposed the sin in people's hearts, because his words and actions showed God's perfect standard. At the same time, his light also helped people understand what God is really like—his goodness, his mercy, and his desire for people to walk in truth (see John 1:4–5, 9; 3:19–21; 8:12; 9:5; 12:35–36, 46).

In the writings of John, "light" stands for God's holiness and his clear revelation of what is right. "Darkness" refers to false teaching and to living without self-control or obedience to God. These two ways of life cannot mix. People who walk in the light live in the truth of God. People who walk in darkness follow what is false and harmful (1 John 1:6).

1 John 1:5–2.6

Here John focuses on the first part of living in fellowship with God. To live in the light means that Christians see that they are sinners. It also means they understand that Jesus is their Advocate, the one who speaks for them and makes them right with God (see Ephesians 5:6–13).

1 John 1:6

This is the first of several times when John challenges the claims of the Gnostics. These teachers had separated themselves from the fellowship of the apostles, so they were living in spiritual darkness. They claimed to have fellowship with God, but they did not show God's character, which is light.

Jesus warned the Jewish leaders of his day not to let the light they believed they had become darkness (Matthew 6:23). Their religious beliefs kept them from receiving the true spiritual light that Christ offered. In the same way, the Gnostic teachers believed they were enlightened, but their teachings actually led them into darkness.

They claimed to receive spiritual experiences from God. Yet they rejected fellowship with the apostles, who had truly seen God in the flesh in the person of Jesus Christ.

1 John 1:7

Christians share fellowship with each other and with God when they live in the light. A person cannot claim to have fellowship with God and then refuse fellowship with God's people. This was the behavior of the Gnostics. The apostles of Christ had known Jesus Christ as God in the flesh, and they continued to have spiritual fellowship with him (1:3).

1 John 1:8

If we say we have no sin: This is the second false claim of the Gnostics (see 1:6). They trusted they could be free from sin because Christ had removed their sins forever. They believed that their special knowledge put them in a position where sin no longer mattered. But Christians do still sin when they live in their old nature (see Romans 7:14–25). A true Christian both acknowledges this sin and trusts Christ to take it away (1 John 1:9).

1 John 1:9

To stay in continual fellowship with God, we need to confess our sins to him. God promises to forgive and cleanse us, and we can trust this promise because God is faithful and just. Christ died for our sins, and his death satisfies God's justice and removes our guilt.

1 John 1:10

If we say we have not sinned, we make Him out to be a liar: God's word highlights how sin affects everything deeply (see study note on 1:8).

1 John 2:1

- In order to "walk in the light," a person must confess sin to God and stop sinning (1:5–7; 9). John emphasizes sin in chapter 1 to encourage Christians to reject and avoid it.
- if anyone does sin: Christians should reject sin, but they should not fear confessing sins to God.
- advocate: The Greek word paraklētos means "one who is called to our side." It can mean helper, comforter, or advocate (a person who speaks for us in a court). Christ is our advocate. He stands before the Father and speaks on our behalf (see Romans 8:26–34; compare John 14:16).
- Jesus Christ, the Righteous One: We are sinful, but Christ is righteous. Because Christ obeyed the Father fully and offered himself for our sins, he can stand before God as the one who brings us forgiveness, healing, and restoration. When God raised Christ from the dead, it showed that God accepted Christ's work and his plea for our acquittal once for all (see Romans 4:23–25). As the Protestant Reformer Martin Luther wrote, "The righteousness of Christ stands on our side; for God's righteousness is, in Jesus Christ, ours."

1 John 2:2

the atoning sacrifice: The Greek word hilasmos means "a sacrifice that takes away sin" (see 4:10). Christ dealt with our sin through his death, which shows God's justice (Romans 3:25).

1 John 2:3–6

- Obedience is one clear indication that we know Christ and belong to him. If we do not obey Christ, it is obvious that we do not belong to him or love him.
- As we obey Christ and his commandments, our love for God and our knowledge of him will grow toward completeness and maturity. We will walk as Jesus walked, united with God and showing love for others.

1 John 2:7–11

The disciples received this commandment (to love one another) from the very beginning. They received it from Jesus himself and from the Old Testament (John 13:34–35; Leviticus 19:18, 33–34).

1 John 2:8

- a new commandment: Jesus gave a new basis for their love by showing love to his disciples through his actions (John 13:1–17).
- the darkness is fading and the true light is already shining: The light of the good news about Jesus pushes back the darkness. Darkness cannot defeat this light, especially when believers live out the love that is in Christ.

1 John 2:9

his brother: The Greek word adelphos is a general term often used to refer to both male and female members of the same family (also in 2:11).

1 John 2:9–11

Another sign that a person truly knows Christ is how that person treats other Christians. John again speaks about people who claim to have special spiritual knowledge but separate themselves from other believers and act as if they are better than others. John says that this attitude is a form of hatred.

1 John 2:10

- To cause others to stumble can also mean to ensnare or entrap them. The Greek word skandalon means a trap or a block in someone's path. The Gnostics taught false ideas about Christ, and their teaching harmed people by trapping them in error and darkness.
- remains in the light: Living the way God wants will help, not harm, the faith of other Christians.

1 John 2:12–14

John describes three groups of Christians at different stages of spiritual growth:

- God's children,
- the young in the faith (literally young people), and
- the mature in the faith (literally fathers).

1 John 2:15–17

The world is a morally evil system that is under the influence of Satan and is opposed to God and to Christ's kingdom on this earth (2:16; 3:1; 4:4; 5:19; John 12:31; 15:18; Ephesians 6:11–12; James 4:4). The world appeals to people's fleshly desires and turns them away from God. People who belong to the world in this way need God to rescue them from it.

1 John 2:18

- Antichrist literally means "instead of Christ." The antichrist will claim what belongs to Christ and act as a substitute for Christ (see 2 Thessalonians 2:3 and Revelation 13:1–10).
- many antichrists have appeared: These are false teachers who deny that Jesus is the Christ, God's Son, God in the flesh (1 John 2:22–23; 4:2; 2 John 1:7).

1 John 2:19

- They went out from us: This is John's first clear statement about the false teachers. At one time, these teachers were part of the church community. They shared fellowship with John and with the other apostles. Later, they chose to leave that fellowship. They also formed a separate and exclusive group that followed false teachings about Jesus (see 4:1; 2 John 1:7; 3 John 1:9–10).
- none of them belonged to us: True Christians would have remained in fellowship with the apostles and remained faithful to their teachings.

1 John 2:20–23

You, however, have an anointing from the Holy One: The Holy Spirit gives Christians the ability to recognize spiritual truth (see Isaiah 61:1; Acts 10:38; 2 Corinthians 1:21–22). Those who have the Spirit know the truth about the Father and the Son. They can also identify teachings that do not match the apostles' teachings.

1 John 2:22

John identifies as a liar any false teacher who denies that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and the one who reveals the Father in a unique way (4:2).

1 John 2:24–25

John urges the people he is writing to resist the lies of these antichrists and remain faithful to the truth that he and the other apostles taught. If they remain in this truth, they will stay in fellowship with the Son and with the Father and will have confidence that they possess eternal life (John 3:15, 36; 6:40, 47, 57; 17:2–3).

1 John 2:28–29

To remain in Christ means, in part, not being misled by any kind of false teaching. If those John is writing to follow false teachers, they will not be in fellowship with Christ. They will have reason to be ashamed when he returns because they will experience judgment.

1 John 3:1–3

- When Christ returns, we will be like him, for we will see him as he really is. God's children bear the image of Christ and will share in his glory (see Romans 8:18–30).
- Those who have this hope keep themselves pure, seeking to become more like Christ as they await his glorious return. It is partly for this reason that God's children will not be ashamed when Christ comes (1 John 2:29).

1 John 3:4–10

This section explains what it means to live a pure life (3:3). Being part of God's spiritual family requires living a pure life. A life full of sin shows that someone is not truly God's child. Sin is not suitable for the new nature that comes from spiritual birth.

John encourages Christians to do what is right to show they are united to Christ and his righteousness. Children of God do not make a practice of sinning. However, this is different from the kind of "sinlessness" claimed by the false teachers (see 1:5–10 and corresponding study notes).

1 John 3:6

- remains in Him: The Greek word menō means "to remain" or "to stay." It describes "abiding" or "remaining" in Christ (John 15:1–8) instead of departing into false teaching. When we live in ongoing and dependent fellowship with Christ, and when we remain faithful to the apostles' teaching, we will not continue in sin.
- continues to sin: This verb describes sin as an ongoing or repeated action. John was not saying that a single act of sin means a person does not know God. Instead, if a person continues to sin without turning away from that sin, that pattern shows a lack of relationship with God.

1 John 3:8

destroy: This word does not mean "to destroy completely." It means "to break down," "to undo," or "to make ineffective" (see Ephesians 2:14). Christ did not completely destroy Satan. Instead, he came to undo the works of the devil by freeing people from sin and from the terrible results of sin.

1 John 3:9–10

To practice righteousness means to live in a right relationship with God. This is different from what the false teachers claimed. They taught that their spiritual life was not affected by what they did in their physical bodies. Living righteously does not mean that we live perfect lives (1:8). It means we confess our sins and stay in a right relationship with God (1:9).

1 John 3:11–22

John now emphasizes that Christians need to love one another (see John 13:34).

1 John 3:12–13

Cain, who belonged to the evil one: Cain was jealous that Abel received approval from God. This jealousy led to murder (Genesis 4:8). God judges hatred, just like the outward act that results from it (see Matthew 5:21–22).

1 John 3:14

Having love for our fellow Christians is clear evidence that we have been born again and will have eternal life instead of death and judgment (see Romans 6:23; James 5:20; Revelation 21:8).

1 John 3:16–18

Christ's example shows that real love requires self-sacrifice. We follow his example when we care deeply about the needs of other people. This means giving our time, effort, prayers, and possessions to help them. In some cases, it may even mean giving our lives to meet their needs.

1 John 3:19–22

Those who truly love (3:16–18) can feel confident that God accepts them. This kind of love shows that their faith is real and that they have new life in Christ (see 4:7–8).

1 John 3:23–24

John gives a new way to recognize who has the Spirit. The Spirit does not belong only to a small group of people who claim to have special knowledge but do not show changed lives. Instead, the Spirit comes to all believers and leads them to live in obedience as followers of Christ (Galatians 5:22–23).

1 John 4:1

every spirit: The teachers who left John's churches said they were prophets, but a true prophet is someone the Holy Spirit uses to bring his message (Acts 4:25; 1 Timothy 4:1; Revelation 19:10). Every speaker should be tested by comparing their message with what the Holy Spirit has already said through the apostles (1 John 4:2–3, 6).

1 John 4:1–6

Those who belong to God can tell the difference between spiritual truth and error (4:4). The presence of the Holy Spirit teaches them (3:23–24; see 2:20, 27; John 14:15–26; 16:5–15). Yet John gives clear tests that Christians can use so that there will be no confusion. These tests are a beginning point for identifying true teachers, not a complete list. John designed them to answer the false teachings that were spreading in the churches of the people he is writing to.

1 John 4:2

By this you will know the Spirit of God: If someone claims to be a prophet, John provides a test for them. True prophets and teachers, guided by the Spirit of God, confess that Jesus Christ came in a real body ("in the flesh"). This means they must confirm that Jesus is both fully human and fully God. Those who deny these basic teachings are antichrists (2:18).

Some false teachers in John's time, called Docetists, taught that Jesus only appeared to have a human body. They denied that God truly became flesh (see 1:1–3; John 1:14).

1 John 4:5

The viewpoint of the world is shaped by evil and stands in opposition to God (2:15–17).

1 John 4:6

- We are from God: John tests whether a person truly belongs to Christ by seeing if that person listens to the teachings of the apostles and agrees with them.
- The Spirit of truth is the Holy Spirit (John 14:17, 26; 15:26; 16:13–15). The Holy Spirit teaches the truth about Christ (1 John 2:20, 27).
- **False prophets** have a spirit of deception. This is the spirit of antichrist, which leads people away from Christ (see study note on 2:22). For this reason, staying united with the historic body of Christ and remaining faithful to the shared teaching that began with the apostles shows loyalty to Christ's work in the world.

1 John 4:7–21

John explains where a Christian's love comes from and how it is shown in daily life.

1 John 4:8

God is love: God is the source of all love and shows what true love is. This truth, together with the truth that "God is light"(1:5), forms the foundation for John's message in this letter.

1 John 4:9–10

Jesus Christ, whom God the Father sent, showed God's love in his life on earth. He also showed this love in his sacrificial death on the cross, where he became the sacrifice that reconciles us to God.

1 John 4:11–12

Those who have received God's love will also love others who belong to God. When we show love to one another, it becomes clear that we truly love God.

1 John 4:15

Those who believe in Christ live in God, and God lives in them. The Father and the Son share this close fellowship (John 10:38; 14:10; 17:21). Christians receive this same gift of fellowship with God, which is a special privilege (see John 14:20; 15:5; 17:21–24).

1 John 4:17

- love has been perfected: The Greek word translated as has been perfected means mature and complete. It does not mean without flaw. This confidence motivates us to mature in our relationship with God, and God's love completes our love.
- Experiencing and expressing God's love and doing what it requires does not make us acceptable to God. But it guarantees us that we have been accepted, and our fears of the final judgment disappear.

1 John 4:18

- Perfect love drives out fear: As we live with Christ and grow more mature and complete in God's love, we have confidence in facing the day of judgment. This day will be terrifying for those who do not know God (Acts 24:25; Romans 2:16).
- Based on a sense of guilt, people fear the punishment they know they deserve. This fear produces dread, and that dread is like a small experience of the coming punishment. Christ died to set us free from this dread (Hebrews 2:14–15).

1 John 4:19

God loved us first, even when we were still sinners and had not yet turned away from sin (Romans 8:5–11). God began this work. Because he loved us, he gave us the ability to respond to him with love and to show that same love to other people.

1 John 5:1–5

Those who believe that Jesus is the Christ and the Son of God have been born spiritually as children of God (see John 20:31). The Spirit of God empowers them to love God and others. Their faith helps them obey God and resist the evil temptations in the world. Through faith, they can love and obey God.

1 John 5:6

This is the One who came by water and blood: A teacher named Cerinthus, who lived at the same time as John, taught a false idea. He said that "the Christ" came down as a spirit on the man Jesus at his baptism, but left him before Jesus died.

John teaches the truth. The baptism and death of Jesus confirmed his identity as the Christ, the Son of God. Jesus of Nazareth was and is truly the Christ, the Son of God, from the beginning and forever.

1 John 5:7–8

- there are three that testify: The Holy Spirit came down on Jesus at his baptism (see John 1:32–34). The water refers to the water in which John baptized Jesus (see Matthew 3:13–15; Mark 1:9–11). The blood refers to the blood Jesus shed when he died on the

cross (see Mark 15:37–39). These three (the Spirit, the water, and the blood) together proclaim that Jesus is God's Son (1 John 5:6).
- After the phrase three that testify, a few very late manuscripts add the phrase in heaven—the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one. And we have three witnesses on earth. This longer reading was written in Latin several centuries after John. It was meant to explain the three elements in the passage (water, blood, and Spirit) as symbols of the Trinity.

Later, this explanation appeared in some Latin copies of 1 John, including later versions of the Latin Vulgate. Erasmus eventually translated it into Greek and included it in the Textus Receptus, which means "received text." Because of this, the longer reading was included in the King James Version.
However, the longer reading is not found in any Greek manuscript before the 1700s. None of the early church fathers mention it. For these reasons, most modern English translations do not include the longer reading as part of the original text of 1 John.

1 John 5:11–12

Whoever has the Son has life: Those who have the Son of God living in them have God's eternal life now. They enjoy the presence of God's Spirit (2:20, 25, 27). They have the guarantee of eternity with God (see Ephesians 1:13–14).

1 John 5:16

Sins that lead to death are sins of apostasy, which means turning away from the true faith and rejecting Christ (see Matthew 12:31–32; Hebrews 6:4–6). In the context of this letter, apostasy means leaving the teaching of the apostles and joining a false, anti-Christian group like the ones John warns about in his letters.

1 John 5:17

there is sin that does not lead to death: Sins that do not involve complete rejection of faith can lead to repentance and restoration (see James 5:20).

1 John 5:20

- John states that Jesus Christ is the only true God (see John 1:1, 18; 20:28; Romans 9:5; Titus 2:13; 2 Peter 1:1).
- we are in Him: Having fellowship or being united with Jesus Christ means having eternal life, because he is eternal life (see 1 John 5:12; John 1:4; 3:16; 14:6; 20:31).

1 John 5:21

In his closing words, John urges his community to stay away from anything that might take God's place in their hearts. The literal wording is "keep yourselves from idols." In the context of 1 John, the main "idol" would be any false teaching that leads people away from Jesus Christ, who is fully human and fully God.